# EW 15 THE SUBJUNCTIVE (1)

Hitherto, the verb forms that you have studied have been part of what is called the «indicative mood»; the subjunctive is another «mood» and it is used in very specific contexts, which you will see later. In English it has all but disappeared from the language or it has taken the form of the indicative, so you are not aware that you are using it. In French, however, it remains an important part of the language.

## 88. FORMATION OF THE PRESENT SUBJUNCTIVE:

In order to find the subjunctive stem for regular verbs, take the **third person plural** of the present indicative, remove the -ent and add the subjunctive endings

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| donner : | ils **donn**ent | → | **donn** | | |
| vendre : | ils **vend**ent | → | **vend** | + | **-e, -es, -e, -ions, -iez, -ent** |
| finir : | ils **finiss**ent | → | **finiss** | | |

Hence . . .

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| *je donn**e*** | *je vend**e*** | *je finiss**e*** |
| *tu donn**es*** | *tu vend**es*** | *tu finiss**es*** |
| *il donn**e*** | *il vend**e*** | *il finiss**e*** |
| *nous donn**ions*** | *nous vend**ions*** | *nous finiss**ions*** |
| *vous donn**iez*** | *vous vend**iez*** | *vous finiss**iez*** |
| *ils donn**ent*** | *ils vend**ent*** | *ils finiss**ent*** |

Some verbs, which form the stem in a regular way for most parts of the present subjunctive, change the stem in the **nous** and **vous** forms:

| | |
|---|---|
| *boire:* | **boive**, *boives*, *boive*, *buvions*, *buviez*, *boivent* |
| *prendre:* | **prenne**, *prennes*, *prenne*, *prenions*, *preniez*, *prennent* |
| *recevoir:* | **reçoive**, *reçoives*, *reçoive*, *recevions*, *receviez*, *reçoivent* |
| *tenir:* | **tienne**, *tiennes*, *tienne*, *tenions*, *teniez*, *tiennent* |
| *venir:* | **vienne**, *viennes*, *vienne*, *venions*, *veniez*, *viennent* |
| *voir:* | **voie**, *voies*, *voie*, *voyions*, *voyiez*, *voient* |

It follows that compounds of any of the above verbs will go through exactly the same changes:

eg *apprendre:* **apprenne**, *apprennes*, *apprenne*, *apprenions*, *appreniez*, *apprennent*

With the exception of two verbs (see below) all verbs have the same endings as the above, even though some have an irregular stem. This irregular stem must be learnt separately. Note that in *aller*, *valoir* and *vouloir* the stem changes in the *nous* and *vous* forms.

| | |
|---|---|
| *aller:* | **aille**, *ailles*, *aille*, *allions*, *alliez*, *aillent* |
| *faire:* | **fasse**, *fasses*, *fasse*, *fassions*, *fassiez*, *fassent* |
| *il pleut:* | *il* **pleuve** |
| *pouvoir:* | **puisse**, *puisses*, *puisse*, *puissions*, *puissiez*, *puissent* |
| *savoir:* | **sache**, *saches*, *sache*, *sachions*, *sachiez*, *sachent* |
| *valoir:* | **vaille**, *vailles*, *vaille*, *valions*, *valiez*, *vaillent* |
| *vouloir:* | **veuille**, *veuilles*, *veuille*, *voulions*, *vouliez*, *veuillent* |

**The two verbs with different endings in some of their parts are:**

| | |
|---|---|
| *avoir:* | **aie**, *aies*, *ait*, *ayons*, *ayez*, *aient* [Note particularly the spelling of the 3rd person singular] |
| *être:* | **sois**, *sois*, *soit*, *soyons*, *soyez*, *soient* |

## 89. FORMATION OF THE PERFECT SUBJUNCTIVE

As with the perfect tense of the indicative (the **passé composé**) the perfect subjunctive is a compound tense, which means that it is made up of two parts:

**auxiliary verb in the present subjunctive** (either **avoir** or **être**) + **past participle of the verb**

All rules of agreement (and non-agreement) in the perfect subjunctive are exactly the same as for the *passé composé* in the indicative

Hence:

| | |
|---|---|
| j'**aie** fait | je **sois** venu(e) |
| tu **aies** fait | tu **sois** venu(e) |
| il **ait** fait | il **soit** venu |
| elle **ait** fait | elle **soit** venue |
| nous **ayons** fait | nous **soyons** venu(e)s |
| vous **ayez** fait | vous **soyez** venu(e)(s) |
| ils **aient** fait | ils **soient** venus |
| elles **aient** fait | elles **soient** venues |

You will possibly not yet understand what the following sentences mean but you can see that there is a preceding direct object agreement on the verb in the perfect subjunctive:

**Il a attendu que je les aie finies**

**Il faut que tu les aies finies avant ce soir**

**WHEN TO USE THE SUBJUNCTIVE**

Caution: The subjunctive is used in the circumstances which appear below. It will become clear that in many cases the subjunctive is used after *que*; do not assume that it will always be used after *que*. If in doubt, assume that you will be using the indicative unless there is a case for using the subjunctive as defined below.

## 90. After certain conjunctions

- **The subjunctive will ALWAYS be used after**:

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| although | : | **bien que** (two words) or **quoique** (one word) |
| supposing that | : | **supposé que** |
| provided that | : | **pourvu que** |
| not that | : | **non que** |
| unless | : | **à moins que + ne** before the verb |

| | |
|---|---|
| Although he is happy he refuses to speak | *Bien qu'il soit heureux il refuse de parler* |
| I will do it provided I am paid | *Je le ferai pourvu qu'on me paie* |
| We will go out unless it rains | *Nous sortirons à moins qu'il ne pleuve* |

- **IF THERE IS A DIFFERENT SUBJECT** either side of the conjunction the subjunctive will be used after:

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| without | : | **sans que** |
| in order that | : | **pour que** or **afin que** |
| before | : | **avant que** |
| for fear that / lest | : | **de peur que + ne** before the verb **or** **de crainte que + ne** before the verb |

| | |
|---|---|
| We did it without him knowing | *Nous l'avons fait sans qu'il le sache* |
| Let's go now for fear that he wants to come | *Partons maintenant de peur qu'il ne veuille venir* |
| I got up so that she could (had the chance to) sit down | *Je me suis levé pour qu'elle puisse s'asseoir* |
| I got up so that she was able to sit down (and did) | *Je me suis levé pour qu'elle ait pu s'asseoir* |
| *NB puisse = the aim only (she had the chance); ait pu = she actually managed to sit down.* | |
| We had lunch before she went out | *Nous avons déjeuné avant qu'elle soit sortie* |

- **IF THERE IS NOT A DIFFERENT SUBJECT** either side of the conjunction use an infinitive after:

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| without | **sans** | in order that / to | **pour** or **afin de** |
| before | **avant de** | for fear that / of | **de peur de** or **de crainte de** |

| | |
|---|---|
| We did it without knowing he was there | *Nous l'avons fait sans savoir qu'il était là* |
| I got up in order to switch on the radio | *Je me suis levé pour allumer la radio* |
| We had lunch before we went out | *Nous avons déjeuné avant de sortir* |

- **NEVER use the subjunctive after**:
  as soon as : **dès que** or **aussitôt que**
  after : **après que**
  whenever : **chaque fois que**

## 91. How to translate UNTIL

**until + NOUN** : **jusqu'à**
Until her arrival *Jusqu'à son arrivée*

**until + VERB** : **jusqu'à ce que + SUBJUNCTIVE** (`to wait until' is an exception)
We read until he told us to stop *Nous avons lu jusqu'à ce qu'il nous ait dit de nous arrêter*

**to wait until + VERB** : **attendre que + SUBJUNCTIVE**
They waited until we finished *Ils ont attendu que nous ayons fini*

**not . . . until + VERB** : **ne . . . que lorsque + INDICATIVE** (possibly future/conditional )

- think of this as meaning `only . . . when'; never split up the *que lorsque*

- I will not open it until he arrives *Je ne l'ouvrirai que lorsqu'il arrivera*